

FOOD

CULINARY COUP

Indian cuisine is having a moment with ***Chef Himanshu Saini****'s Trèsind Studio, Dubai, making it to 11th place in the World's 50 Best Restaurants list*



"I don't call it modern Indian cuisine anymore. If people outside India don't know what authentic Indian food is, how can we narrate our story?" says chef Himanshu Saini. Riding high off Trèsind Studio's win on the World's 50 Best Restaurants list, it has been a great streak for the chef, including recognition in Dubai's Michelin Guide, MENA's 50 Best Restaurants list, etc.

Keen to put India on the world culinary map, Saini is keener on doing it right. Eager to replace the greasy image of curries with a refined gourmet touch, he goes the extra mile to juxtapose tradition and technique. The culmination is a two-hour immersive degustation experience that promises seasonal produce and a redefined perception of Indian food.

The menu at Trèsind Studio spans all four regions of India. "The one dish on the menu I'm really proud of is the 'Sadhya'. Inspired by Kerala, the dish is performed at the table. We've taken an element from all 25 traditional dishes and added our own touch to curate a small dish on the plate. I've seen people cry over this because it's such an auspicious ceremony, and the choreography around this dish has every chef from the kitchen involved at the table," says the chef.

With Dubai being a melting pot of cultures, Saini admits there couldn't have been a better place to narrate his story. "Back in the day, say, 30 years ago, the people outside India cooking Indian food did it out of necessity," he says. "Of course, this isn't counting the likes of chef Vineet Bhatia and chef Atul Kochhar, etc., who have laid the foundation for young chefs like us. Now, in the last decade or so, we have seen the rise of passionate chefs who are travelling abroad, getting inspired and making Indian food cooler and more popular."

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Which explains why Trèsind Mumbai has been at the forefront of a larger food revolution across India. Bringing the concept of a tasting menu back home, Saini hopes to convey his personality and cooking philosophy to diners. "Mumbai is my city, the place that made me a professional chef. The dishes that go out of the menu at Trèsind Studio make it to Trèsind Mumbai, with a few tweaks and use of seasonal ingredients, of course," he says. The aim at Trèsind Mumbai remains to push people out of their comfort zone, forcing them to get adventurous with their palate and explore.

Now that Avatara, Saini's Sattvik Indian restaurant in Dubai has made its mark with a Michelin star in its debut year, Mumbai will play host to a branch by the end of the year. Armed with that, great ambitions and a determination to narrate the story of Indian flavours right, chef Saini is one to watch. ■

Caroline Felicia D'Almeida